Four Elements Inspiration Guide

Revised October 26, 2026 · Complete revised text, retaining the original document’s page sequence and reference imagery.

Source page 1

FOUR ELEMENTS — GAME FEEL & CREATIVE
DIRECTION

Companion creative brief | Revised October 25, 2026

Purpose: This document describes the intended experience, not a replacement for the Master Specifications. When implementing systems, Codex should use these principles to make reasonable presentation and usability recommendations, but must not invent mechanics that conflict with the specification. References are inspiration for feel and function, not instructions to copy assets or code.

1. The emotional promise

Four Elements should make the player feel that they are traveling through a living Avatar world with Team Avatar— allowing them to play out the exact storyline of Avatar the last Airbender scene for scene. The world we are building should be open and full of small details and secrets, making Players curious about what lies beyond the next door, excited to recognize a familiar place, and increasingly capable of changing their surroundings and fighting off the wild creatures, mercenaries, and fire nation army through the skills they have learned.

It should feel adventurous, warm, mysterious, funny, and sometimes genuinely dangerous. Its world is worth exploring even when no quest marker points the way. Combat is consequential, but the overall game is not relentlessly bleak. Moments of relief, companionship, beauty, and discovery are essential contrasts to difficult
battles and the escalating stakes of the story.

The player should feel clever when solving an environmental problem, observant when discovering a hidden reward, proud when winning a difficult battle, and connected to the party when character abilities complement
one another.

2. Reference DNA: what to borrow

- Pokémon Gen 3: The excitement of reaching a new city/town to explore, finding a hidden route, exploring a cave, recognizing that an old obstacle is now passable with newly learned skills, and revisiting a region with newly learned capabilities. Memorable routes and meaningful boundaries, not a featureless continuous map. The party tracking system should resemble a party of pokemon, where players are able to customize their movesets, give special items, and overall plan their party strategically. Also map / world layout style
- Harry Potter and the Prisoner of Azkaban for Gameboy advanced (POA): Character-specific exploration mechanics, magical-feeling environmental interaction, puzzle spaces that ask the player to observe and experiment, and the pleasure of coordinating party members and leveling them up

individually. Techniques should feel learned and embodied. Also world layout

- Stardew Valley: A readable, charming pixel-art world with enough detail that a bush, crate, drawer, shoreline, or path edge might reward attention. Gathering should be relaxing and satisfying, not a chore or an endless checklist. World should feel alive and abundant and colorful and full of hidden easter eggs and items and locations

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- Darkest Dungeon: seriousness of battles, variable damage, hit uncertainty, hard choices, and enemies that punish having no strategy. Importantly, difficulty should come from readable risks and meaningful choices, not arbitrary obscurity or forced grinding.

These references are not equal in every situation. Exploration should be inviting; combat should be demanding. Neither should erase the other.

VISUAL REFERENCE ATLAS — screenshots and design takeaways

For Codex: The screenshots below are actual reference-game screenshots, not mockups of Four Elements. Read each caption alongside the creative brief. The image is the visual evidence; the caption identifies the particular property to study. Do not assume everything visible in a screenshot is a requested feature. These images are hosted at their credited source URLs, but screenshots have been attached. Do not copy proprietary sprites, textures, UI graphics, music, or code into the game. Implement original assets and systems reflecting the approved design principles.

A. Pokémon Emerald — readable outdoor routes, boundaries, and exploration

Reference A1 — Pokémon Emerald, outdoor route. Study: saturated yet readable pixel-art terrain, obvious walkable paths, vegetation defining the route, NPC placement, and distinct encounter terrain. Apply to Four Elements: similarly inviting visual clarity and purposeful regional layouts, but with richer environmental interactions, layered elevation, and more physical movement. Do not copy: the exact tiles, grass sprites, or Pokémon encounter rules. Screenshot source: Eurogamer.

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A1:

Reference A2 — Pokémon Emerald Seaglass, obstructed route (fan-made variant, not original Emerald). Study: a visible, memorable obstruction that suggests a return trip after acquiring a traversal ability. Apply: boulders, ice, cliffs, gates, streams, and tunnels should advertise future opportunities. Unlike a single-use HM rock or tree, Four Elements' objects should react through reusable capability and material rules. Screenshot source: Mr. Walkthroughs.

A2:

Reference A3 — Pokémon Emerald Seaglass, obstructed route (fan-made variant, not original Emerald). Study: a visible item on the ground that can be picked up, as well as a body of water that can be traversed using the correct move. Apply: items can be available and visible on the overworld, not just in containers Screenshot source: Mr. Walkthroughs.

A3:



Reference image from original page 3



Reference image from original page 3

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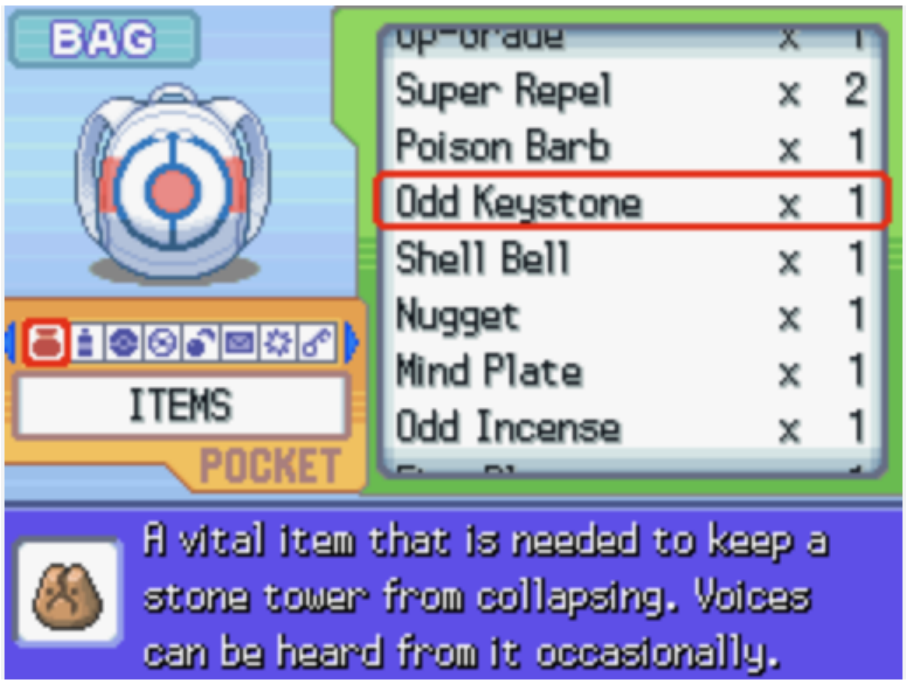
Reference A4 — Pokémon Gen 3/4 bag UI. Study: bag segmented into loot types Apply: this is how Appas storage should be structured, but rather than the names of the items, I want it to to show up like Stardew Valley
chests that we carousel through.

A4:

B. Prisoner of Azkaban (GBA) — character-led narrative and compact information, exploration, Combat layout and design



Reference image from original page 4



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Reference B1 — Harry Potter and the Prisoner of Azkaban (GBA), party and story prompt. Study: small expressive characters, legible group staging, and a readable story instruction integrated into the game.
Apply:
Team Avatar's distinctive sprites, group positioning, dialogue prompts, and story-driven transitions. Do not copy: the specific Hogwarts interface or character sprites. Screenshot source: GamePro gallery.

B1:

Reference B2 — Prisoner of Azkaban (GBA), Combat UI, character and ability interface. Study: character portraits for current character turn, visible numerical information, compact ability and menu icons, and information hierarchy. combat order in top right of image shows combat order (Hermione, enemy1, harry, enemy2, ron) for this turn. Encounter shows enemy party across from player’s party. Apply: a clear character-specific identity, readable SP/HP and equipped actions. Combat order indicator, general character and enemy layout. Important: Four Elements has a separate turn-based combat scene and its own approved combat loadout rules; this is primarily a UI reference, not a combat-layout mandate. Screenshot source: GamePro gallery.

B2:

Reference B3 and B4 — Prisoner of Azkaban (GBA), Combat UI, layout, environmental effect on battle, environmental attacks, attack animations. B3: Study: combat encounter B3 shows “Horklump Spores appear on the battlefield and blast enemy with pollen.” Apply: the surrounding environment may become a variable in



Reference image from original page 5



Reference image from original page 5

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combat encounters. Characters may be able to create environmental variables with special moves or abilities.
Do Not Infer: that the layout will be exactly the same as depicted in the image. Image B4: Study: Enemies have their own level, health bars, and unique attacks. Enemy attack is portrayed with words, and an animation
of the goblin jumping forward and attacking. APPLY: enemy name, health, stat, info graph. All moves, from our
characters or enemies will have unique animations. Both enemies and our characters will have “taking damage” animations.

B3:

B4:

Reference B5 — Prisoner of Azkaban (GBA), exploration and discovery. Study: Harry is in his room and finds a letter on the bed that he is able to read, there is also a chest in the corner that can be opened. Apply:

readable objects. Show characters icon with dialogue when reading or thinking.

B5:



Reference image from original page 6



Reference image from original page 6

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Reference B6 — Prisoner of Azkaban (GBA), puzzles and world traversal. Study: Hermione is capable of freezing water with a spell in order to cross a section of the map that is otherwise inaccessible. Understand: characters will be traversing the map using special abilities that they gradually learn.

B6:

C. Stardew Valley — world feel, loot handling, material richness, and personal spaces

Reference C1 — Stardew Valley, chest transfer interface. Study: clearly separated container/chest and player inventory, stacks and item icons, quick visual scanning, and choosing which resources to move. Apply: openable chests, drawers, Appa storage, baskets, stashes, etc. take-all/select-some/leave-all interactions, quick move items with shift click. Do not infer: that the final backpack must use this exact grid or slot limit; Pokémon-like pockets are also part of the brief.

C1



Reference image from original page 7



Reference image from original page 7

Source page 8

Reference C2 — Stardew Valley, player arranged storage, items, and decorative objects. Study: objects that are functional and expressive of player preference, a compact but personalized space, and clear placement on
the world grid. Apply: Appa's mobile campsite as a customizable “home”, persistent arrangement, storage furniture, crafting stations, souvenirs, and decorations. Pay Attention: the camp should not look like an indoor house. It will be outside in the open world at designated Appa fast travel locations. It will not require identical geometry at every landing point. Items that can not fit on the ground should go into a side bar to be placed down by the player if necessary. Camp items may include: campfire to cook, tents, item upgrade station, level
up skill station, storage containers connected to Appas storage, and potentially other Avatar related content Screenshot source: player-shared Imgur album.

C2:

Reference C3 — Stardew Valley, open world with items and foraging. Study: stardew valley has foragable foods in the open world, from root vegetables to fruit bushes, as well as multiple different types of resources that can be collected in the open world.

C3:



Reference image from original page 8



Reference image from original page 8

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D. Pokémon Emerald — portable-home customization precedent

Reference D1 — Pokémon Gen 3, Secret Base customization. Study: how a small game world can support furniture placement, trophies, decorations, and a sense of ownership without becoming a building simulator. Apply: the player's tent at portable Appa campsite will have a non-canon interior where players can decorate

their camp with all the special loot items they have collected throughout the game, with useful and purely decorative finds, equipment, and a persistent layout. Difference: Appa's camp moves between eligible locations and has story-dependent availability. Screenshot and background: GamesRadar.

D1:

E. Darkest Dungeon — tactical stakes and combat legibility

Reference E1 — Darkest Dungeon, turn-based combat. Study: simultaneously visible party and enemy formations, actionable skill choices, health, accuracy, critical chance, and speed indicators. Apply: combat decisions based on readable risk, meaningful costs, status and enemy intent. Target choosing, targeting limitations, position limitations. Difference: Four Elements should retain Avatar's colorful, adventurous tone, its
own turn order, and its own party rules. Four Elements Combat interface will look more like Prisoner of Azkabans, with heroes in the foreground and enemies across in the distance. Screenshot source: NoobFeed review.

E1:



Reference image from original page 9



Reference image from original page 9

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Reference E2 — Darkest Dungeon, impactful critical attack. Study: immediate damage feedback and a dramatic consequence of decision. Enemy strikes friendly character for a higher damage critical hit. Note that
there are character unique animations for each move. Apply: readable hit/miss/crit/status results, significant attacks that feel powerful, and visual feedback appropriate to Avatar bending. Some moves may take 2 turns to
activate, some moves may cause damage to both the caster and target, some moves may have lasting effects
for multiple subsequent turns. Do not copy: gothic imagery, gore, stress mechanics, or its exact HUD.

E2:

Reference E3 — Darkest Dungeon, visible statistics-based chance. Study E3: note that both friendly and enemy characters have stats for all aspects of combat and stats are visible. Implement: we want our stat system to work very similarly to Darkest dungeon with accuracy levels, crit rate, variable damage, Dodge, Protection, Speed, and resistances - Stun, Debuff, Move



Reference image from original page 10



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E3:

F. Resident Evil 4 — Puzzles and collecting items

Reference F1 — Resident Evil 4 puzzle items Study E3: the player has to collect various items in order to unlock a doorway. Each item is in separate locations in the world and need to be searched for.
F1:

G. Death Howl — Tactical Movement, Battlefield Positioning &
Turn-Based Combat

Reference G1 — Death Howl, tactical combat battlefield.

Study: Compact, top-down pixel-art battlefields where characters and enemies occupy physical positions rather than standing in fixed formations. The battlefield is divided into navigable spaces, allowing the player to move strategically, approach enemies, avoid dangerous positions, and use the surrounding environment.

Apply: Four Elements should use a similar approach to turn-based combat. When an encounter begins, the player enters a compact tactical battlefield based on the surrounding overworld location. Nearby rivers, trees, boulders, structures, and other environmental features may become part of the encounter.



Reference image from original page 11



Reference image from original page 11



Reference image from original page 11

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Characters should move by selecting a destination within their available movement range. Each character ordinarily has one movement allowance and one primary action per turn. Movement should be important for positioning, avoiding attacks, approaching elemental resources, and preparing techniques.

Do Not Infer: That Four Elements will use Death Howl's deckbuilding mechanics, action-point economy, or exact movement grid. A square-grid system is a strong candidate but should be evaluated by Codex before final implementation.

G1:

Reference G2 — Death Howl, movement range, targeting & enemy positioning.

Study: How the game communicates available movement, attack ranges, enemy positions, and tactical opportunities through a compact, readable interface. Positioning and distance influence which actions are possible and how effectively the player can respond to enemies.

Apply: Four Elements should clearly display a character's available movement range when selecting a destination. Hovering over a location should preview the intended path and movement cost. When selecting a technique, the game should communicate its range, affected area, eligible targets, and relevant environmental interactions.

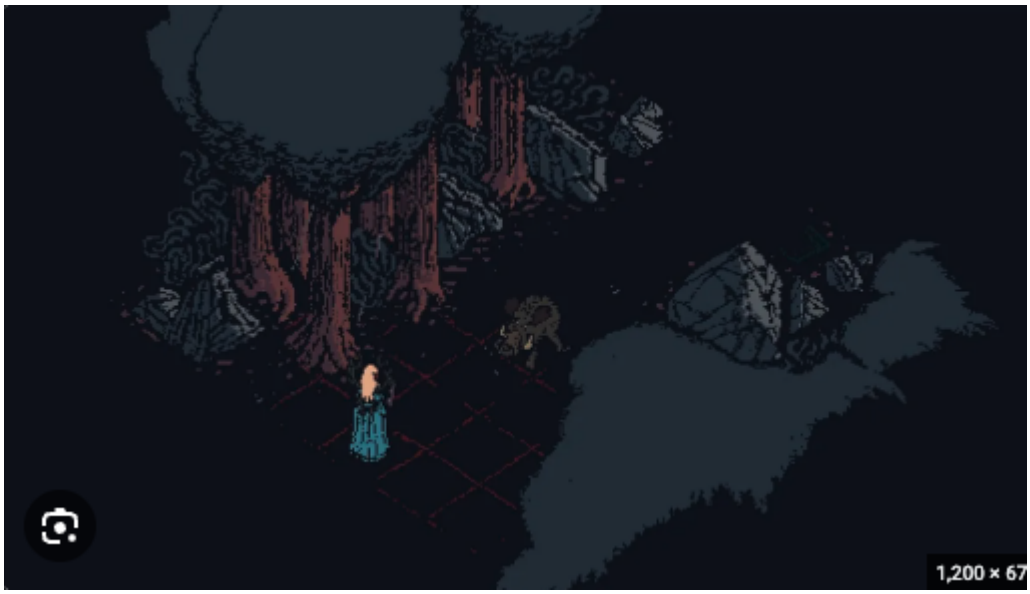
Positioning should matter for every character. Katara may move toward water to access stronger bending techniques. Toph may reposition to manipulate earth or create barriers. Sokka may use trees, rocks, and structures as cover. Aang may use his mobility to avoid danger or reach advantageous positions.

Enemy characters should also move, seek cover, approach targets, and react to changes in the battlefield.

G2:



Reference image from original page 12



Reference image from original page 12

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Reference G3 — Death Howl, enemy attack patterns & tactical decision-making.

Study: How enemy positioning, attack ranges, and recognizable attack patterns encourage players to anticipate threats rather than simply exchange damage. Movement can be used defensively, offensively, or to prepare for a subsequent turn.

Apply: Four Elements should reward observation and intelligent positioning. Enemies may indicate their intended attacks, allowing players to move out of danger, raise defensive barriers, interrupt preparations, or reposition vulnerable party members.

Combat should encourage multi-turn planning. A character might spend one turn creating cover, another manipulating that cover into an attack, or use a temporary defensive technique in anticipation of an enemy's powerful move.

Environmental changes should persist across turns when appropriate. A tree destroyed by firebending should no longer provide cover. A newly created earth wall should obstruct movement and attacks until destroyed, removed, or otherwise affected.

Reference G4 — Death Howl, compact tactical combat integrated with pixel-art exploration.

Study: How a pixel-art RPG can combine exploration with a distinct tactical combat experience while maintaining a consistent visual identity. Battles are small enough to remain readable but contain sufficient space for movement and tactical decisions.

Apply: Four Elements should maintain a cohesive pixel-art aesthetic between its overworld and combat scenes. Battlefields should visually reflect the location of the encounter without requiring a full recreation of every overworld feature.

Combat should generally take place on a single navigable plane. Permanent battlefield elevation should not create positions where characters become effectively untouchable.



Reference image from original page 13

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Instead, vertical movement should primarily be represented by temporary technique states inspired by Pokémon's Fly and Dig. Characters may become Airborne, Elevated, Burrowed, or Submerged, changing their vulnerability and available actions for a limited duration.

For example, Toph might raise herself on a temporary earth pillar to avoid an anticipated attack, then spend her next turn's movement allowance descending. Such techniques should have appropriate weaknesses and counters.

G4:

Overall Design Takeaway

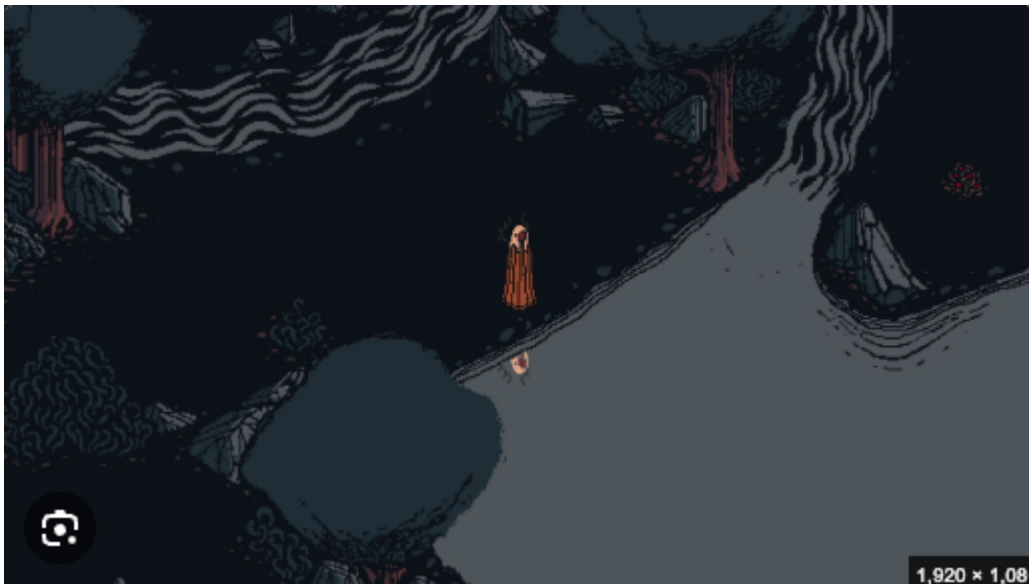
Death Howl should serve as the primary reference for the physical structure and movement of Four Elements' tactical combat.

Prisoner of Azkaban remains the reference for character portraits, combat information, distinctive animations, and accessible interface presentation. Darkest Dungeon remains the reference for statistical depth, difficulty, status effects, and consequential decisions. Pokémon informs equipped movesets, progression, and multi turn moves and techniques. Baldur's Gate 3 contributes inspiration for creative environmental interactions.

Four Elements should combine these strengths into a combat system where characters actively move, use cover, manipulate terrain, anticipate enemy actions, and employ bending techniques that change the battlefield.

The goal is for combat to feel like an Avatar battle: dynamic, strategic, expressive, and fundamentally shaped by movement and the environment.

Codex should inspect the existing Godot project and evaluate grid-based navigation, click-to-move movement allowances, targeting, environmental interactions, and temporary positioning states before proposing an implementation architecture.



Reference image from original page 14

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H. How these references combine

The references contribute different functions, not competing templates. Pokémon guides readable exploration, equipped moves, and temporary positioning techniques. Stardew Valley informs gathering, environmental detail, and visual storage. Prisoner of Azkaban informs character presentation, dialogue, puzzles, and readable combat information. Resident Evil 4 informs multi-location item puzzles. Darkest Dungeon informs combat statistics, risk, and consequences. Death Howl is the leading reference for compact tactical combat, click-to-move positioning, and enemy attack patterns. Baldur's Gate 3 informs creative environmental combinations, without requiring its 3D navigation.

Exploration supports genuine layered topography. Combat generally uses a single navigable plane with temporary technique-driven vertical states. The written Technical Guide governs approved rules; Codex should identify remaining uncertainties and seek approval before changing architecture.

Four Elements is not intended to recreate any one of these games. It combines the strongest aspects of their exploration, world design, character interaction, combat, inventory, and progression systems into a cohesive RPG built around the world, characters, and original story of Avatar: The Last Airbender.

The result should feel like a game that could have existed during the Game Boy Advance era, but with the scale, interactivity, depth, and technical capabilities of a modern game engine.

World Design, Exploration & Traversal

Pokémon Emerald establishes the foundation for how the world is organized and explored. Regions should feature recognizable pathways, towns, wilderness, buildings, caves, hidden locations, and environmental obstacles. The player should regularly encounter places that invite exploration or suggest opportunities to return with new abilities.

Stardew Valley contributes environmental richness and interactivity. The world should contain plants, ingredients, crafting materials, treasures, containers, and useful objects. Players should be rewarded for examining their surroundings, interacting with the environment, and venturing beyond the main story route.

Prisoner of Azkaban contributes character-driven exploration and ability-based puzzles. Individual members of Team Avatar should possess distinctive skills that allow them to interact with the world in different
ways. Newly learned abilities should expand what players can accomplish, opening new routes, solving puzzles, and revealing previously inaccessible locations.

Four Elements extends these ideas with significantly greater physical freedom and environmental complexity. Its world should feature meaningful elevation, overlapping pathways, cliffs, rooftops, underground passages, caves, and vertical traversal. Characters should be able to use bending, agility, and other learned abilities to manipulate their surroundings and reach new areas.

Environmental interactions should generally follow reusable material and ability rules rather than existing solely
as scripted puzzle solutions.

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Character Presentation, Dialogue & Discovery

Prisoner of Azkaban is the primary reference for the presentation of playable characters and story interactions.

Characters should have expressive, recognizable pixel-art sprites, with portraits and dialogue that communicate their personalities. Objects discovered in the world may prompt dialogue, observations, or reactions from individual party members.

Players should be able to inspect letters, books, containers, mechanisms, and other objects, with discoveries contributing to storytelling, puzzles, and exploration.

Team Avatar should feel like a group of distinct characters traveling together, rather than interchangeable units.
Their relationships, humor, observations, and evolving abilities should remain central to the experience.

Combat Presentation, Tactical Movement & Depth

Prisoner of Azkaban is the strongest visual reference for combat presentation. Battles should take place in a separate turn-based battle scene, with Team Avatar positioned in the foreground and enemies across the battlefield. Character portraits, health and stamina information, equipped techniques, and the upcoming turn order should be clearly presented.

Every character and enemy should have recognizable combat animations, including unique technique animations, attacks, defensive actions, and reactions to taking damage.

Darkest Dungeon is the primary reference for combat depth, statistics, and meaningful tactical decisions.

Combat should reward preparation, intelligent technique selection, awareness of enemy strengths and weaknesses, and careful resource management. Accuracy, dodge, protection, critical chance, damage ranges,
speed, resistances, status effects, targeting limitations, and initiative should all contribute to the outcome of encounters.

Different techniques should have distinct tactical purposes. Some may require preparation across multiple turns, affect several targets, manipulate battlefield conditions, cause lasting effects, or involve meaningful risks
and tradeoffs.

The environment itself should sometimes participate in combat, as demonstrated by Prisoner of Azkaban's environmental attacks. Terrain, available materials, hazards, and character abilities may create opportunities or complications that change how an encounter unfolds.

Pokémon contributes the accessibility and clarity of a turn-based RPG, while Darkest Dungeon contributes the
strategic depth and consequences. The goal is combat that is approachable to understand but challenging to master.

Visually and emotionally, battles must remain consistent with Avatar's adventurous, expressive world—not Darkest Dungeon's gothic atmosphere.

Inventory, Resources & Collectibles

Updated combat reference priority: Death Howl defines navigable battlefield structure and click-to-move positioning. Prisoner of Azkaban defines readable portraits and character-specific UI, not stationary formations. Darkest Dungeon informs statistical decisions. Battlefield features can be manipulated across turns. Combat is ordinarily single-plane; temporary Airborne, Elevated, Burrowed, or Submerged states supply vertical tactics without permanent height-based immunity.

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Pokémon provides the organizational reference for categorized inventories, with separate pockets for different types of items.

Stardew Valley provides the reference for visual item management, including recognizable item icons, stack quantities, storage containers, and convenient transfer interactions.

Appa's storage should combine these ideas: categorized storage with visual item grids that players can browse, rather than relying primarily on text lists.

The world should contain a broad variety of collectible items, including crafting materials, ingredients, consumables, equipment, scrolls, valuable treasures, decorative objects, and rare discoveries that unlock techniques or contribute to discipline progression.

Items should be found through exploration, foraging, combat, trading, containers, hidden areas, and puzzle

completion. Some treasures may have several uses, creating meaningful choices about whether to consume, equip, trade, craft with, or display them.

Inventory management should be satisfying and intuitive, with enough resource management to reward preparation without constantly interrupting exploration.

Appa's Campsite — A Portable, Customizable Home

Pokémon's Secret Bases provide the reference for personalizing a small space with collected furniture, trophies, and decorations.

Stardew Valley provides the reference for arranging functional and decorative objects in a living environment.

Together, these inspire Appa's campsite: a portable home that travels with Team Avatar and evolves throughout the adventure.

Players should be able to customize the campsite's outdoor arrangement with tents, cooking equipment, storage containers, crafting stations, training facilities, decorative objects, souvenirs, and other discoveries. Functional upgrades may improve cooking, recovery, storage, crafting, and training.

The campsite should exist physically within suitable outdoor locations rather than functioning only as a menu.
Its layout and contents should persist when the party travels, while accommodating the different terrain and available space at each landing location. Objects that cannot fit should remain available for later placement.

The player's tent should also have a customizable interior, inspired by Pokémon's Secret Bases, where collected decorations, treasures, and meaningful objects can be displayed.

The camp should feel personal and rewarding to develop, but remain recognizably Team Avatar's traveling home rather than becoming a permanent settlement or elaborate building simulator.

Appa's location and availability must continue to follow the original story, including periods when the party cannot access the full campsite or its stored supplies.

Puzzles, Secrets & Environmental Challenges

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Prisoner of Azkaban demonstrates how character abilities can transform the environment and unlock new routes.

Pokémon demonstrates how visible obstacles, hidden items, and newly acquired abilities encourage players to revisit locations.

Resident Evil 4 contributes the idea of larger environmental puzzles involving the discovery, collection, and placement of important objects. Puzzle components may be distributed across rooms, structures, or entire areas, requiring exploration, observation, combat, and problem-solving before the player can proceed.

Four Elements should incorporate all of these approaches.

Some puzzles may be solved through a single clever bending interaction. Others may require multiple characters, coordinated abilities, collected objects, environmental transformations, or exploration across several connected locations.

Enemies may inhabit puzzle areas, and certain challenges may require players to alternate between combat, exploration, and environmental manipulation.

Puzzles should feel naturally integrated into the Avatar world, with solutions grounded in the characters' capabilities and the physical properties of their surroundings. Mandatory story progression must remain completable even when players make unexpected choices.

The Overall Experience

The combined experience should be:

- As inviting and readable to explore as Pokémon Emerald.
- As rich with discoveries, resources, and personal expression as Stardew Valley.
- As character-driven in its exploration, puzzles, dialogue, and combat presentation as Prisoner of Azkaban.
- As tactically demanding and consequential in combat as Darkest Dungeon.
- As rewarding in its larger environmental puzzles and treasure hunts as Resident Evil 4.
- As faithful as possible to the characters, humor, emotional depth, worldbuilding, and events of the original Avatar: The Last Airbender series.

These references are not competing design directions. Each contributes a particular strength to the same game.

The defining feature of Four Elements is that its exploration, combat, puzzles, character progression, resources, and campsite all belong to one interconnected world. A technique learned during the story might improve combat, unlock a hidden passage, help solve an environmental puzzle, or reveal a rare treasure
that can be used back at camp. The player should continually discover new reasons to explore familiar places as Team Avatar grows more capable.

The game should preserve the charm and immediacy of classic handheld RPGs while providing a substantially
larger, more responsive, and more interactive Avatar world.

Instructions for Codex

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These screenshots are visual and experiential references, not instructions to reproduce another game's assets
or mechanics wholesale.

Codex should study the referenced screenshots alongside their captions, identify the specific presentation and
interaction principles being requested, and use them to inform original designs for Four Elements.

The written Master Specification remains authoritative for approved gameplay rules. Where implementation

details are unresolved, Codex should inspect the existing Godot project, evaluate appropriate solutions, and present recommendations rather than silently introducing new mechanics or replacing functioning systems.

The goal is not to make a game that looks exactly like Pokémon, Stardew Valley, Prisoner of Azkaban, Darkest Dungeon, or Resident Evil 4. It is to make an Avatar RPG that captures the best qualities of each while establishing its own cohesive identity.

3. The desired rhythm

A satisfying play session might look like this:

1. Arrive at a kyoshi island and notice several possible routes to take.
2. Talk to someone in the village that needs some help
3. Go explore
4. Collect an ingredient or find a small reward off the main path.
5. Encounter an obstacle that responds to a technique already learned—or if not, remember it for later.
6. Switch to the party member whose abilities best fit the problem.
7. Solve a puzzle through deliberate input, not an automatic contextual prompt.
8. Meet a character, advance the story, or find a hidden space.
9. Enter a battle that requires attention to enemy intent, stamina, status, and risk.
10. Recover, improve a technique, and find the trinket the person in town needed.
11. Play out the events of the ATLA series by talking to a specific person
12. Zuko attacks and you need to fight him then escape to the next location

The world should alternate between quiet discovery, active manipulation, social/story moments, and bursts of danger. Avoid repetitive encounters that interrupt puzzle concentration or turn every few steps into combat.

4. Exploration: curiosity over instruction

Do not constantly tell the player exactly which move to use. Present materials, environmental clues, and visually legible mechanisms so the player can form a hypothesis. The player deliberately selects a move from their learned catalog/hotbar and aims it. A technique can work in many places when its utility and the object's
reaction profile are compatible.

A successful interaction should feel like the world responded logically, not like the player found the single scripted answer. Optional areas should reward unusual combinations, careful observation, and returning with new mastery. Sometimes not thinking ahead will be punishing, like destroying a boulder versus moving it to a

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place that blocks a piece of treasure. Mandatory paths should never require an unavailable party member or inaccessible technique. There will be places where you need to discover or learn the technique previously in the game in order to advance, similarly to have in pokemon you need to learn cut, rock smash, or swim before
being able to explore certain areas fully.

Hidden rewards should be discoverable, not random invisible pixels. Use environmental composition, unusual object placement, sound, dialogue, lighting, or landmarks to hint at secrets. Like in pokemon, sometimes you will see an item across a body of water, or on a path blocked by a rock. You must remember to come back when you have the necessary skills.

Layered topography and vertical exploration

The world must preserve the inviting, readable top-down pixel-art feel of Pokémon Gen 3, Stardew Valley, and
Prisoner of Azkaban while giving its unusually agile characters meaningful vertical terrain. Mountainsides, ledges, rooftops, raised walkways, ravines, underground chambers, caves, tunnels, and overlapping routes should be part of exploration—not merely painted scenery. Height should matter to how a place is traversed, how characters separate, and what secrets they notice.

For example, Aang might use an air-assisted double jump to reach a shelf on a mountainside and glide across a gap. Toph might sense a hollow chamber and uncover a tunnel entrance. Katara might create an icy path near a waterfall; Sokka might spot a concealed route or practical way around an obstacle. These are illustrative
possibilities, not a requirement that every region contain all four solutions. Ordinary characters should feel agile, while extraordinary traversal capabilities remain distinctive and earned.

The player should see an intriguing place and wonder which character, technique, or route will let me get there? Some paths are accessible now, others after learning an ability, and others only after a story event. Elevated routes and underground passages should reward observation without making navigation visually confusing.

Technical boundary: This is a gameplay and presentation requirement, not a prescribed engine implementation. Codex should audit the existing Godot project and compare viable ways to support height, collision, jumping, occlusion, bending targets, followers, separate maps, and saving. Propose an architecture and a small test area for approval before rebuilding existing maps. Do not assume full 3D or a particular tile/elevation solution has been selected.

5. Bending: distinct physical personalities

- Water: Fluid, adaptive, continuous, graceful, able to change state. Manipulation should have smooth visual response and a sense of weight or volume.
- Earth: Grounded, forceful, geometric, deliberate, heavy. Raising stone should feel stable and consequential.
- Fire: Quick, energetic, precise or volatile depending on technique. Heat, ignition, and illumination should have visible reactions and consequences.
- Air: Light, mobile, sweeping, responsive. Motion and momentum should be expressive without sacrificing control.
- Nonbending: Ingenious, practical, observant, resourceful, witty. Sokka's tools, planning, and foraging must feel like valuable specialties, not lesser substitutes for bending.

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Shared interaction utilities are a technical language, not an excuse for every element to feel the same. Two techniques can move an object while differing in animation, momentum, range, material requirements, stamina
cost, and feedback.

6. Party: companions, not interchangeable units

The default follower chain should make the group feel like a traveling team. Party separation should be available when the story, campsite, or designed exploration/puzzle area permits it—not necessarily at every moment. A character may leave the group from camp for a solo excursion. Switching leaders should be immediate and readable. Splitting the party should create opportunities for clever cooperation: one character holds a position, another navigates a separate route, a third activates a mechanism. Reuniting should feel convenient when physically possible, but never teleport companions past a meaningful obstacle.

Aang air scooters over a gap at the air temple, then walks through a doorway into a new zone - the other party
member should not be with him in the new area. Aang needs to unlock the back way around, and regroup with
his companions.

Sustained bending can remain active when the player switches away: a controlled element may hover near the
inactive character while concentration continues to matter. Active aiming and interruption rules require careful
design; switching must not automatically make every held effect permanent.

Story events can remove or relocate companions. Those absences should feel narratively motivated and should be reflected in available interactions, traversal routes, and combat encounters.

7. Combat: harsh, fair, and expressive

Combat should be punishing to lazy repetition, and should reward preparation and intelligent recovery. Attacks have damage ranges, accuracy and critical uncertainty. A strong attack is not always the right attack: SP (Stamina Points) cost, target defenses, elemental context, status, enemy intent, and party synergy should matter.

The player should often think: Can I afford this attack? What happens if it misses? Should I defend, interrupt, conserve stamina, use this item, flee, or take the risk?

A victory should feel earned, not simply inevitable from having a higher level. Conversely, bad RNG should create a difficult situation, not make every thoughtful decision irrelevant. Make odds, ranges, relevant status conditions, and significant enemy telegraphs sufficiently legible. Short, ordinary encounters should remain brisk
and relatively easy; major enemies and bosses can demand sustained planning.

Darkest Dungeon's tactical severity is the reference, not its pervasive hopelessness. Four Elements should retain the adventurous, humane, and sometimes playful emotional character of Avatar. Characters will be exhausted or KO’d to portray defeat, and defeat does not always mean game over. Ordinary party defeat returns the group to the last suitable campsite or authored checkpoint, with a meaningful but not oppressive consequence. Optional Ironman rules may be harsher; a temporary KO is not automatically a canonical character death.

8. Progression: growing capability changes perception

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Character levels improve broad capability; seven discipline masteries (Levels 1–10) deepen broad categories of proficiency: Precision, Area Control, Defense, Manipulation, Transformation, Mobility, and Support. Individual learned techniques draw on primary and sometimes secondary disciplines rather than earning separate move XP. Specialized Advanced Arts are unlocked through character identity, training, and story events rather than forming an eighth discipline. Not every technique upgrade changes traversal capability, but
certain upgrades should transform how the player sees familiar places: a previously uncrossable stream, an unreachable ledge, a frozen waterfall, or a sealed mechanism becomes an opportunity. In battle, discipline development may improve SP efficiency, damage ranges, accuracy, critical potential, or other relevant attributes. Not every discipline improves every property, and exact balance belongs in the Master Specification.

Advanced Arts: individual character identity

Advanced Arts are specialized character-specific ability families, not an eighth generic discipline and not necessarily one special move per character. They may be passive exploration talents, active combat states, new material interactions, or story-unlocked techniques. They should make the player excited to switch characters because each sees and uses the world differently.

- Aang — Avatar State: An extraordinary, story-governed power, initially difficult to control and not a routine combat shortcut.
- Sokka — Perception, Strategy, and Foraging: Uncover hidden routes and resources, read enemy weaknesses, improve tactical preparation, and identify or harvest rare ingredients. His nonbending abilities must remain genuinely valuable.
- Katara — Water Healing: Specialized restorative waterbending that develops with Support and related capabilities, while preserving its narrative learning milestones.
- Toph — Seismic Sense and Metalbending: Detect structures and movement through connected ground, uncover hidden spaces, and eventually interact with metal as a new material. These are distinct specialties.
- Zuko — Exploration and Battle Fury: Agility, infiltration, swordsmanship, and a potential high-risk combat state emphasizing critical potential or offense. The exact name, effects, and evolution with his story are proposed, not yet fixed.

These are creative examples to develop within canonical character arcs. Special abilities should not become interchangeable bonuses or bypass the story's timing.

Backtracking should produce the feeling “I know how to get there now”, not “the game made me repeat this road for no reason.” Appa fast travel reduces dead travel after discovery, while story flags can temporarily restrict arriving at or departing from particular locations for meaningful narrative reasons. Appa will
not always be available, whether or not its because you are in enemy territory and he needs to stay in a cave,
appa is separated from the group, or another reason. Sometimes Appa will be following the group, and others he will be static in one location.

9. World richness and rewards

Foraging, containers, environmental debris, hidden caches, lore, and regional details should make locations feel inhabited and worth examining. Rewards do not all need to be powerful: an ingredient, a note, a

charming
environmental interaction, a fun easter egg from the original series, or a small shortcut can justify exploration.

Food and passive recovery and camping support the journey without requiring oppressive survival meters. Looting should be simple, consistent, and satisfying. The player should not have to fight the inventory UI to

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enjoy collecting things.. Open a chest like in stardew valley or minecraft, and either transfer all items to your inventory or pick and choose, or choose nothing.

Appa's customizable portable campsite: a traveling home

Appa's campsite should be more than a rest menu. It should feel like Team Avatar's little moving home, built up gradually from discoveries and resources gathered throughout Books 1–3. When the group makes camp at a suitable place, players should be able to arrange its layout and contents: bedrolls, cooking gear, chests, lanterns, rugs, souvenirs, crafting tools, training objects, and decorative finds. Placement and, where appropriate, rotation should be player-controlled. Functional objects can also be decorative.

The campsite's preferred layout and owned contents persist as the group travels with Appa. Different camp locations retain their own atmosphere and terrain; the system should handle limited space by safely packing items that cannot fit rather than losing them or placing them inside obstacles. Some camps may be basic temporary camps without Appa or without access to all facilities, depending on story circumstances.

Camp upgrades can improve rest and healing, cooking quality and recipes, storage capacity, crafting/preparation, and training. Progress should come from gathered materials, discoveries, trade, and story milestones. Decorating is an enjoyable optional pursuit; it should not become a mandatory chore or a substitute for character progression. The camp should grow more personal over time without turning into a permanent mansion or a survival-management simulator.

Resources, treasures, crafting, and rewarding discoveries

The world should contain a broad variety of items with meaningful and sometimes overlapping uses: ingredients, crafting materials, tools, equipment, combat consumables, valuables, collectible treasures, scrolls,
quest objects, furniture, and decorative items. Some treasures might grant XP toward a specific discipline, support training, teach or unlock a technique, or provide a distinctive equipment effect. A lantern could decorate camp and also provide light; a discovered artifact might be collectible, tradable, or useful in progression. Exact rewards and limits are balancing decisions, not permission for Codex to invent a complete item economy.

The joy of finding a hidden chest or returning to a remote cave should be enhanced by not knowing whether it
contains a rare material, a practical tool, an exciting scroll, a piece of camp furniture, or a playful reference to
the series. Loot should feel abundant and diverse, while powerful rewards remain earned and paced.

Personal backpacks and Appa's storage

The desired direction is simple, Pokémon-inspired pocket organization for each character's carried items,

separate from equipped gear and combat loadouts. Pockets might organize consumables, materials, tools, valuables, scrolls/key items, and decorations; an item can have multiple functional tags even if it appears in one pocket. Appa carries bulk storage, furniture, crafting supplies, and the camp collection when narratively and physically available. Avoid a magically shared party inventory that negates separation or Appa's
absence.

Backpack capacity is not yet finally chosen: generous Pokémon-style storage with sensible restrictions is currently preferred over constant slot-by-slot inventory friction. No weight-based micromanagement is desired.
Preserve and audit the existing inventory implementation before proposing a migration. Story-essential items must not become irretrievably inaccessible when Appa is absent.

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10. Pixel-art visual direction

Aim for a bright, readable, expressive top-down/isometric-inspired pixel-art world with distinct silhouettes, this should be exactly like stardew valley and Pokemon Gen 3, and POA. purposeful environmental detail, and coherent scale. The Southern Water Tribe should feel icy, open, and wind-swept; other regions should have their own material palettes, vegetation, architecture, weather cues, and ambient life. The world can be colorful
and welcoming while still supporting ominous ruins, dangerous wilderness, and serious story moments.

Movement should feel responsive and consistent in eight directions. Sprite anatomy, perspective, facing, and foot alternation should remain coherent. Cutscenes can be modestly more detailed than gameplay, but should
feel like the same visual universe rather than a completely different art style. Favor clarity of interactive objects
over decorative noise.

References establish visual and gameplay goals, not permission to reuse proprietary sprites, audio, or source code. New assets and implementations should be made for Four Elements.

11. Sound, feedback, and interface tone

Creative guidance, not a finalized asset list: Let each region have a recognizable ambient soundscape. Bending should sound materially different—flowing water, shifting stone, air pressure, flame. Interactions need
prompt, restrained feedback: a mechanism clicks, ice forms, a container opens, a technique fails for a legible reason.

Menus should be quick and understandable, with minimal interruption to exploration. Combat presentation should emphasize HP, SP, statuses, hit chances, and readable consequences. UI should support deliberate play without covering the world in constant tutorial prompts.

12. What the game should NOT feel like

- A series of one-off scripted puzzles where abilities only work on their designated prop.
- An empty world with huge travel distances and little to discover.
- A survival game that forces constant hunger, tool repair, or tedious maintenance.

- A combat system where the strongest move is always the best move.
- A combat system where outcomes feel random because the player cannot understand the risks.
- A party game where companions teleport through obstacles or lose their identity.
- A progression grind where repeated trivial actions are better than meaningful exploration.
- A technical demo whose systems work individually but do not produce a coherent adventure.

13. The creative decision filter for Codex

When choosing between plausible implementations, ask:

1. Does this make exploration more curious, rewarding, and physically understandable?
2. Does the player retain agency in choosing and applying abilities?
3. Does it preserve the distinct identities of characters and elements?
4. Does it reward preparation, observation, and skill rather than rote repetition?
5. Does it fit the tone of an adventurous Avatar journey, including humor, warmth, and danger?
6. Is the system reusable and data-driven rather than tailored only to the example?

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7. Is the implementation readable, testable, performant, and compatible with existing working features?
8. Does the world support meaningful vertical discovery and character-specific routes without sacrificing visual clarity?
9. Does collecting, crafting, and customizing Appa’s camp deepen the sense of a shared journey rather than create busywork?

If the answer conflicts with an explicit rule in the Master Specification, do not override the rule. Flag the tension and ask for a decision.

Architecture and design authority

The creative brief defines desired player experience, not Godot implementation details. Codex should first perform a read-only audit of existing working systems, identify dependencies and contradictions, and propose
technical approaches with tradeoffs for approval. Illustrative scenarios are not exhaustive hardcoded requirements. The Master Specification governs finalized mechanics; unresolved choices should be flagged instead of silently decided.

14. One-paragraph north star

Four Elements is an inviting, richly explorable Avatar The last Airbender Book 1-3 adventure in which Team Avatar party grows from novice benders and warriors into increasingly capable masters of their abilities. The player chooses how to use those abilities, discovers secrets through attention and experimentation, revisits old places with new understanding, and faces turn-based battles that are tense, uncertain, and won through preparation and strategy rather than attack spam. Layered terrain and a customizable traveling camp should make discovery and belonging tangible. The world should feel coherent and reactive; the companions should feel distinct; and every major system should deepen the sense of journey, discovery, and earned mastery. All of this, as the Player lives out the events of Avatar the Last Airbender book 1-3 to ultimately defeat the firelord.